🏁 🔐 🏁 **FRONT MATTER** 🏁 🔐 🏁

All 18F teams are expected to send weekly ship updates so that:

- Stakeholders know the project's status, blockers, and progress toward outcomes
- Executives aren't taken by surprise, and know how they can help

Robin Carnahan explains.

This is a recommended Weekly Ship template; it can be adapted to suit the team.

Suggestions? Contact: 18F Director of Account Management

Weekly ship

How to use

1. Fill the distribution list with names or emails of people to keep up-to-date. Consider adding more people, rather than fewer, to reduce surprises for everyone.
2. Plan to send the ship on the day most helpful to the partner; probably Friday or Monday.
3. Designate a person, or a rotation of people, to captain the weekly ship.
4. Copy the template and paste it under ships, using the date as a heading.
5. Fill in its sections. Invite your teammates to contribute.
    a. Focus on outcomes the team is driving toward, rather than simply listing tasks.
    b. Consider the audience: it could be forwarded around the partner org, or FOIA'd
    c. Fill in "burn" numbers from your account manager.
6. When complete, paste the ship into an email.

7. Send or schedule-send the email to the distribution list in the morning.
8. Post the same text in the #the-shipping-news Slack channel.
9. The next week, bump the prior week's ship down; stack the new one above it.

Distribution list

To:

Cc:

Template

Subject: [Agency Name] / [Project Name] / Weekly Ship: xx/xx/xxxx
[General greeting]

[Write an intro summary note. The first time or two, explain the purpose of the weekly ship.]

Leadership decisions needed

- [When a lack of a decision could lead to a risk, request a decision]

Risks/blockers

- [Tactfully but honestly list risks and blockers our stakeholders should know about]

Progress

- [List what was completed this week and how it relates to project goals. Focus on progress towards outcomes for users, rather than tasks completed.]

What's next

- [List some things that are planned for the near future and the reasons for them -- how will they help get the team closer to the outcomes it wants?]

Planned absences

- [List any team members who will be out of office]

Project finances (“burn”)

- [List your financials for this week: “As of the week ending xx/xx/20xx, of the total budget of $x, we have spent $x in FY2x, leaving us $x or x%. Based on this, this project is set to end on xx/xx/20xx.”]

Ships

[Fill in the send-on date]

[The business day before sending, paste template here and fill it out]